Five Hearts One Home

By

M. A. Harrington

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This story contains mature themes and romantic situations intended for an adult audience.

Written in loving memory of my mother,
who loved Harlequin romance novels
and inspired my first journey into storytelling.

FIVE HEARTS, ONE HOME

A Romance Novella

Table of Contents

Chapter One — The Beginning

Chapter Two — First Date

Chapter Three — The Morning After

Chapter Four — The Barbecue

Chapter Five — The Rules

Chapter Six — Quiet Time with Jackie

Chapter Seven — Sandy Arrives First

Chapter Eight — Saturday Morning

Chapter Nine — Saturday Night

Chapter Ten — Sunday Morning

Chapter Eleven — Jamie Finds Her Voice

Chapter Twelve — Jamie Takes Control

Chapter Thirteen — The End of Ninety Days

Chapter Fourteen — Time with Jackie

Acknowledgements

There are some stories we write because an idea won't leave us alone.

And then there are stories we write because someone we love inspired us to pick up the pen in the first place.

Five Hearts, One Home is the second kind.

This was the first story I ever wrote, and I wrote it in memory of my mother, who loved Harlequin romance novels. I remember thinking that if she could enjoy so many stories about love, perhaps I could create one of my own.

I never imagined that first attempt would become the beginning of my journey as a writer.

Mom, this story is for you.

Thank you for giving me a love of stories, even if you never knew where that love would eventually take me. Every time I write, I carry a little piece of that inspiration with me.

I would also like to thank the readers who are willing to step outside the familiar and experience a love story that may look different from their own experiences. Thank you for allowing these characters to be imperfect, complicated, vulnerable, and human.

Most of all, thank you for remembering that every story is ultimately about people.

People who want to be loved.

People who want to belong.

People who sometimes make mistakes and need forgiveness.

People who are simply trying to find their way home.

And to anyone who has ever felt that their way of loving was somehow too different, too complicated, or too far outside the lines—

Thank you for letting me tell this story.

With love,

Marie ❤️

A Special Acknowledgement

I would also like to acknowledge ChatGPT, an AI writing and editing assistant, for helping me revise, polish, and refine this story. While the ideas, characters, emotions, and story belong to me, this tool helped me see my words differently and gave me another perspective during the editing process.

I am grateful for the creative partnership that helped me bring this story back to life and prepare it for readers.

Author's Note

I wrote this story in memory of my mother, who loved Harlequin romance novels and inspired me to write my own love story. As my first story, it will always hold a special place in my heart.

But *Five Hearts, One Home* became more than a story I wrote for my mom.

It became a story about love.

We often grow up believing that love is supposed to fit neatly into a box. Society has created ideas about what a relationship should look like, how many people should be involved, and what love is supposed to mean. But love has never been quite that simple.

There are many ways to love, and there are many ways for people to build a life together.

This story explores one of those possibilities.

I wanted to show that people in LGBTQ+ relationships are not fundamentally different from people in heterosexual relationships. Beneath the labels, we all share many of the same basic human needs. We want to be loved. We want to feel desired, respected, safe, valued, and understood. We want someone to listen when we're hurting, hold us when we're afraid, celebrate with us when we're happy, and choose us—not because we are perfect, but because we are ourselves.

We may express love differently. We may build relationships differently. We may choose lives that don't look like everyone else's.

But that doesn't make the need for love any less universal.

Five Hearts, One Home isn't meant to suggest that one way of loving is better than another. It is simply an invitation to look beyond the boxes society sometimes creates for us and remember that, at the heart of every relationship, there are human beings searching for connection.

And perhaps that is what we all have in common.

We all want somewhere we can belong.

Somewhere we can be ourselves.

Somewhere we can love and be loved.

Somewhere we can call home.

To my mom, this story is for you.

And to every reader who has ever felt that they didn't quite fit inside the box the world handed them—

I hope you find your home, too. 💔

Five Hearts One Home

By

M. A. Harrington

Chapter 1: First Meeting



Jackie, impeccably dressed in a knee-length black skirt and crisp white blouse, felt a knot of nervous energy tighten in her stomach. This was important. Her client, Mark, a burgeoning artist whose talent she believed in fiercely, was having his first solo exhibition at a prestigious new gallery. She wanted to make a good impression, and her conservative attire reflected that. She looked younger than her thirty-five years, her blonde hair A short, chic crop framing a face that, despite her apprehension, held a natural radiance. Her light blue eyes, usually sparkling with wit, were today more focused, determined.

The gallery, a converted warehouse space with exposed brick walls and high ceilings, buzzed with activity. The air thrummed with the low hum of conversation, the clinking of glasses, and the soft murmur of appreciation as guests admired Mark's vibrant, emotionally charged canvases. Jackie arrived later than she intended, a late-afternoon traffic jam delaying her, and immediately began her search for her client. The gallery, despite its stylish ambiance, felt overwhelming in its size and the sheer number of people milling about.

Then she saw her—a vision in tight black jeans and a simple white polo shirt. The woman held

an empty wine glass. Her eyes, a striking electric green, radiated an intelligence that mirrored the intensity evident in Mark's paintings. Unexpectedly, a thrill shot through Jackie; a visceral reaction to the woman's captivating presence. Jackie's heart pounded a slightly faster rhythm against her ribs.

Spotting someone with a tray laden with wine glasses, she quickly approached, selecting two—one for herself, and one for the captivating woman who had already piqued her interest. Jackie approached cautiously, wanting to make a good impression. She approached the woman, who was engrossed in studying one of Mark's paintings.

"Hi," Jackie began, her voice calm and confident. "My name is Jackie. I saw you were out of wine, so I thought I'd bring you another glass. I hope you don't mind, and I hope I don't offend whoever you came with," she added, a touch of self-deprecating humor in her tone.

The woman turned, her surprise quickly giving way to a look of polite interest. Her gaze, lingering on Jackie's face, seemed oddly intense, almost searching. The woman's beauty was striking, but it was her effortless elegance that truly captivated Jackie.

"Hi, my name is Rachel," the woman replied, her voice soft but clear. "And I'm actually here alone. I came because this is my best friend's first showing. He's the artist," she added with a warm smile.

A wave of relief washed over Jackie. "What a coincidence," she exclaimed, her smile mirroring

Rachel's. "Your best friend is also my client. I actually helped him secure this gallery for his exhibition. He's incredibly talented," she added, gesturing toward a particularly striking piece near them.

They began to discuss Mark's artistry, their shared appreciation for his work bridging the gap between them. After a brief moment of comfortable conversation, Jackie confessed she hadn't managed to find him in the crowd. The gallery was, she observed, quite crowded. Rachel nodded in agreement, adding that she hadn't seen Mark either.

Rachel's sudden anxiety caught Jackie's attention. "What's wrong?" Jackie asked gently.

"I need to use the restroom," Rachel admitted, a hint of distress in her voice. "And I can't seem to find it."

"I know where it is," Jackie offered, her smile reassuring. "Follow me."

Jackie led Rachel to the restroom, a small, elegantly appointed space tucked away discreetly. Rachel practically rushed to an unoccupied stall. Jackie took the opportunity to quickly scan the room. Assured they were alone; she slipped the lock into place.
Rachel emerged from her stall a few moments later, surprised to find Jackie still there. "Did you need to use the restroom, too?" she asked, a hint of confusion in her voice.

Jackie's smile was slow, deliberate. "No, not really. I just wanted a little time alone with you, to

talk. I'd like to get to know you better. To be honest, I am intrigued with you. Tell me, when was the last time you had an orgasm?" Jackie's unanticipated question hung in the air.

Rachel laughed, a throaty sound that sent a delightful shiver down Jackie's spine. "What kind of question is that to ask someone?"

Jackie's smile widened, her eyes gleaming with amusement and a hint of boldness. "Well, I'd really like to kiss you. If you'd let me," she added suggestively.

Rachel, caught off guard but clearly intrigued by Jackie's confident approach, responded with a soft smile. "Sure," she said, her voice barely a whisper. "What's one kiss going to hurt?"

The kiss began tentatively, but quickly escalated. A shared magnetism sparked an immediate erotic tension between them. Their lips met, their hands reaching out, discovering the contours of each other's bodies under the fabric of their clothes. Jackie gently pushed Rachel away, her voice a husky murmur against Rachel's ear. "Not this time.

Just me touching you."
Jackie swiftly unbuttoned Rachel's jeans, her fingers gracefully sliding beneath the denim to caress the soft skin of Rachel's inner thigh.

A deep moan escaped Rachel's lips as Jackie continued her exploration. Rachel's passion

mirrored Jackie's. She eagerly kissed Jackie, simultaneously caressing Jackie's breasts through the thin fabric of her blouse. Rachel's climax was swift and intense; a wave of pleasure that left her breathless.

Once the intensity subsided, Jackie calmly withdrew her hand and washed it before pulling out her business card from her pocket.

"Please call me," she said softly, handing the card to Rachel. "I'd love to continue this conversation…over dinner."

Jackie then unlocked the bathroom door, leaving Rachel in a state of satisfied longing, her mind already anticipating their next encounter.

Chapter 2: First Date

 Rachel hesitated for several days before calling Jackie. The memory of their encounter in the gallery restroom was vivid, a potent cocktail of surprise, arousal, and intoxicating desire. The thought of Jackie, the unexpected kiss, the thrilling touch—it played on repeat in her mind, keeping her awake at night. She worried about appearing too eager, too forward. What if Jackie thought she was…desperate? The label "slut" felt suddenly too close for comfort. But the longing to speak to Jackie, to feel her near again, proved too much to resist. Finally, summoning every ounce of courage, Rachel dialed the number on Jackie's business card.

Jackie's voice, warm and inviting, sent a shiver down Rachel's spine the moment she answered. "Hello, this is Rachel," she managed, her voice barely a whisper, betraying the turmoil churning within her. The nervousness was palpable—a stark contrast to her usual composure.

Jackie, sensing Rachel's anxiety, responded with gentle understanding. "How's your day going? Is everything alright?" The words were a balm to Rachel's frayed nerves.

Rachel's internal monologue raged. I never act like this before with anyone. Why does this woman do this to me? Aloud, she managed only a shaky, "My day is going well. How about you?"

Jackie's reply was cheerful. "My day just got better because you called. How about you join me for dinner? I'll text you the directions to the restaurant. Do you have something semiformal to wear tonight?"

Rachel found herself hesitating slightly. "Yes, I think so?" The uncertainty in her voice was

apparent even to her own ears.

Jackie's response was a confident, "Good. Meet me at the restaurant at six-thirty sharp. Please be on time," before hanging up.

Rachel glanced at the clock; the ticking hands seemed to mock her. "Oh shit, I have to hurry!" She grabbed her phone; it had already vibrated with the text message containing the directions.

Rachel's preparations were a whirlwind of excitement and nervousness. She chose a knee length black cocktail dress, the fabric clinging subtly to her curves. Black rhinestone studded stilettos, elegant bangles, a delicate necklace, and a matching hair clip complemented the dress, and a coordinating handbag completed her ensemble. Her makeup was carefully applied—a conservative elegance that enhanced her natural beauty rather than obscuring it.

When Rachel arrived at the restaurant, the transformation was startling. She felt like a different person entirely compared to the woman who'd hurried into the art gallery that afternoon. She walked with a newfound confidence, the elegant dress and heels adding to her already considerable presence. It was clear that this Rachel was more than ready for the evening—and for Jackie.

As Rachel stepped into the restaurant, the first person she saw was Jackie. And everyone— it seemed—noticed Jackie also. Her figure was stunning in a long, scarlet cocktail dress. A daring slit that climbed almost to her hip showed off her long legs.

Gold bangles and a necklace gleamed against her skin, perfectly complementing the red stilettos

with gold accents and matching handbag. Her makeup was flawless, expertly applied to enhance her facial features. Rachel's breath hitched in her throat; it felt like they were completely alone in the room.

Jackie stood up, her warmth palpable, and waved Rachel over to the table. The level of sophistication and confidence that emanated from her was awe-inspiring; Rachel felt a rush of exhilaration and apprehension at the same time. She couldn't fathom how she would maintain any control over her desires.

As she approached Jackie, Rachel found herself utterly captivated by the effortless grace and chic confidence Jackie exuded. The red dress accentuated her figure magnificently. Rachel felt a mixture of nervousness and excitement.

Jackie extended her hand, a warm smile lighting up her face. Rachel, taking Jackie's hand in hers, grasped it gently, feeling her heart race. Then, with a slight gasp, Rachel quickly released Jackie's hand and took her seat across from her.

The two women sat momentarily, looking into each other's eyes, their mutual attraction creating a palpable tension. Jackie, not one to let the moment linger, initiated the next move. She slipped off one of her stilettos with a deft movement, and then, her leg reaching beneath the table, gently brushed her foot against Rachel's leg.

Rachel's reaction was instantaneous—a startled yelp, and then a gasp escaped her lips. Jackie,

attempting to hide her laughter, quickly covered her face with a napkin. Rachel now had the full attention of the other diners in her vicinity. Mortified, an embarrassed flush spreading across her cheeks, Rachel quickly recovered her composure. “I’m sorry,” she said to the others in the restaurant. “I’m extremely jumpy tonight.” She then turned to Jackie, her voice a low growl. “What the hell were you thinking?”

Jackie lowered the napkin, revealing a devilish grin. “Well, firstly, I didn’t expect that reaction and secondly, I thought it might be helpful to break the tension so that we could enjoy our dinner together.”

Rachel’s lips curved into a smile. “I think it’s working.”

“Great,” Jackie said, her voice brimming with mischief. “Let’s order some food and drinks. I’m starving!”

After their dinner, they decided to continue their date at Rachel’s home—an invitation Rachel hadn’t anticipated. Yet, there was a compelling inevitability to the natural evolution of their evening. Jackie followed Rachel in her car, parking behind Rachel’s.
Simultaneously, they exited their cars and started toward the house, leaving the quiet suburban street behind. Rachel fumbled with her keys; her hands trembled as she awkwardly attempted to insert the key into the lock. Observing her shaking hand, Jackie gently took the keys, unlocking the door.

Stepping through the threshold, Rachel made a clumsy attempt to carefully set her purse down

on a nearby table. Instead, the contents spilled unceremoniously onto the floor, a cascade of assorted items that looked more like the result of a tiny explosion. Rachel completely lost control, and she found herself collapsing onto the floor, overwhelmed by a sudden torrent of tears.

“I don’t know what the fuck is wrong with me,” she sobbed, her voice broken. “You make me such a nervous, hot, freaking mess!”

Jackie, her expression softening with concern, knelt beside Rachel, gently lifting her into her arms and wiping away her tears. Jackie gently cupped Rachel’s chin, their eyes met, and another kiss ignited a fresh burst of passion. The kiss transformed the initial tenderness into a passionate embrace. The emotions that surged between them were raw, powerful, and undeniably compelling.

Within minutes, shoes and dresses lay discarded on the floor, their earlier careful attire having given way to a shared desire that overrode all social niceties. Bras and panties followed soon after, abandoned on the stairs as their ascent to Rachel’s bedroom unfolded.

The night culminated in a passionate embrace, a series of intense, and completely satisfying orgasms. Their emotions, desires, and physical intimacy had finally found release, ending the evening with both women asleep in each other’s arms. The night couldn’t have unfolded any more dramatically, or for both women, any more delightfully.

Chapter 3: The Morning After

 Jackie awoke to find Rachel still fast asleep in her arms, her head resting gently on her bosom. Jackie gently caressed Rachel's hair, marveling at its softness. A soft murmur stirred her from her reverie. "Last night was amazing," Rachel whispered, her voice thick with sleep.

Jackie smiled, a warmth spreading through her chest. "I couldn't agree more," she replied, her voice soft and tender. A serious expression settled on her face. "There's a three-day weekend coming up," she began, her tone shifting. "I'd really like it if you'd come and stay with us for those days. We'll be having a barbecue and lots of fun."

The words "us" and "we" hung in the air, igniting a spark of suspicion in Rachel's mind. Doubt, a cold serpent, began to coil in her heart. She hadn't explicitly asked Jackie about her relationship status. The possibility that Jackie wasn't single, that she had a husband, and that this invitation was a thinly veiled proposition for a ménage à trois, sent a wave of icy dread through her. The thought fueled a fire of anger within her.

Rachel sat up abruptly, her eyes blazing with fury. "Who is 'us' and 'we'?" she demanded, her voice sharp and accusatory.

Jackie, startled by the sudden shift in the atmosphere, attempted to calm Rachel. "Please, just listen before you jump to conclusions," she pleaded, her voice laced with anxiety.

But Rachel, consumed by her emotions, couldn't contain herself. "You aren't single!" she

exclaimed, her voice rising in pitch. “I knew you were too good to be true! Get out! I never want to see you again!”

Tears streamed down Rachel’s face, a torrent of hurt and betrayal. “My heart is fucking breaking right now,” she sobbed. “No one, and I mean no one, has ever made me feel like this. Not in my whole life has anyone made me feel so fucking good in bed. You do it effortlessly. I really was hoping that you and I could be something more. You just fucked it all up for me with those words, ‘us’ and ‘we’! Get the fuck out!!”

Jackie, still lying in bed, responded calmly, “You’re overreacting.”

Rachel took a deep breath, attempting to regain control of her emotions. “So, the ‘we’ and ‘us’ are your children?” she asked, her voice still trembling.

Jackie chuckled softly. “Not exactly. Please, let me explain everything before you make the biggest mistake of your life.”

Rachel grabbed her bathrobe, hastily covering her naked body as she sat on the edge of the bed, facing Jackie, wiping away the tears that continued to fall. Jackie, witnessing Rachel’s pain and anger, felt tears welling up in her own eyes.

And so, Jackie began to recount her past, revealing a truth that mirrored Rachel’s own struggles.

Both women shared a similar history of intimacy issues and a pattern of infidelity in their past

relationships. Jackie explained her own vulnerabilities, her tendency to stray when the initial passion faded. She confessed that this was why she had chosen a polyamorous relationship with Jamie.

Rachel sat stunned, the weight of Jackie's confession settling heavily upon her. Silence descended upon the room, thick and heavy with unspoken emotions.

Jackie broke the silence, rising from the bed. "Please, come to the barbecue and stay for three days," she pleaded, her voice soft but firm. "Come with an open mind and heart, Rachel. I think you're the missing piece to our beautiful home. I want you to be happy. How many times have you hurt someone because you ended up cheating on them? In my house, there are four other women for me to love and receive love from. I'm no longer cheating, and I'm so very happy. Sometimes, people just don't fit in the conventional box. I believe that you're just like me. There are no coincidences, Rachel. I'll text you the directions to my home, and I really hope you'll come."

With that, Jackie quietly gathered her clothes and dressed, leaving Rachel alone with her words, a mixture of pain, confusion, and a flicker of hesitant hope. The weight of the revelation hung heavy in the air, the future of their relationship uncertain, yet pregnant with possibility. The scent of last night's passion still lingered, mingling with the bittersweet aroma of unspoken truths and the fragile promise of a new beginning. The three-day weekend stretched before them, a blank canvas upon which their story would continue to unfold.

Chapter 4: The Barbecue

 The day before the barbecue, Jackie receives a text: Rachel's coming. A wave of both giddy excitement and terrifying anxiety washes over her, a tension that Jamie instantly senses. Their shared secret—Jackie's infidelity with Rachel—hangs heavy between them. Jamie, completely blindsided by Jackie's confession that morning, is heartbroken. Tears stream down her face, a torrent of hurt and betrayal, as Jackie promises to keep their secret safe. Once again, Jamie is left to navigate the aftermath of Jackie's impulsive actions. Their relationship, fragile and complex, is built on a foundation of unspoken truths, secrets that Jamie shares with the other women under a vow of silence. The resulting atmosphere is thick with unspoken tension, a palpable sense of shared knowledge. Jackie, acutely aware of the situation, retreats to her den to escape the undercurrent of emotion. She only emerges when the storm has passed, showering each woman with individual affection. Despite everything, they love Jackie; they understand that even the best of us make mistakes. Meanwhile, Jamie meticulously prepares for Rachel's arrival, ensuring a welcoming and comforting environment.

Rachel, a woman of quiet strength and understated elegance, arrives through the back gate, finding the others gathered around the patio. An almost imperceptible tremor of nervousness runs through her as she takes in the scene—a group of beautiful women, radiating a sense of effortless intimacy. The sight stirs a mixture of apprehension and intrigue within her.

Jackie is at the grill, her movements fluid and graceful as she expertly cooks hamburgers, hot

dogs, and succulent steaks; the aroma fills the air, a tantalizing promise of shared pleasure. The women subtly exchange knowing glances, their eyes lingering on Rachel, understanding the source of Jackie's earlier distress. Rachel's captivating beauty evokes a primal response in some, while in Jamie a pang of bittersweet longing is stirred—a conflict between protectiveness and a secret admiration for Rachel's allure. A current of heightened anticipation runs through the group, a shared awareness of the untold possibilities awaiting them.

Jackie sees Rachel and gently guides her away, a silent understanding passing between them. "Let's talk first," she whispers, a captivating tenderness in her voice, leading Rachel to the bathroom where she can change into a matching robe like everyone else has on. "Just try to be open, okay?" Jackie urges, her voice a soft caress. "Let it unfold naturally; this weekend will be unforgettable." A knock echoes. "Gotta pee!" Jackie quickly kisses Rachel before opening the door to reveal Becca.

Becca, breathtaking in her beauty, dark hair framing a face both striking and sensual, makes Rachel's breath catches in her throat. Jackie sends a reassuring smile to Rachel before gently closing the door, leaving her alone to absorb the emotions swirling within her; a heady cocktail of trepidation, excitement, and a newly awakened curiosity. Becca, her robe partially open, revealing a glimpse of her form, leaves Rachel breathless. The unexpected intimacy is a bold invitation: a silent offer to explore a realm of sensations that she barely dares to envision. Becca's words are simple, yet electrifying— "May I kiss you?"—and Rachel's surrender is an instantaneous, heartfelt yes.

Their lips meet, igniting a fire that consumes and transforms them,

releasing a torrent of yearning and unspoken love. Their bodies intertwine, a dance of exquisite passion, but the moment is fleeting as another knock interrupts their intimacy. “We’ll finish this later,” Becca whispers, a hint of longing in her voice, before opening the door to welcome another.

The arrival of Sandy, a golden-haired vision of beauty and self-assured charm, is another unexpected turn in the dance of attraction. Sandy’s warmth melts Rachel’s initial apprehension, and her gaze holds a depth of understanding, an acknowledgment of the unspoken desires that lie beneath the surface. The touch of Sandy’s hands, deft and playful, sends waves of heat through Rachel, revealing a vulnerability she never expected. Sandy’s uninhibited sensuality gently melts away Rachel’s hesitations, drawing out her own hidden passions; and a cascade of unspoken emotions are released.

The playful entrance of Scissy, a whirlwind of life radiating joyous energy, adds yet another layer to this unfolding tapestry of romance. Rachel encounters a vibrant confidence and infectious enthusiasm; with similar intensity Scissy’s uninhibited sensuality and unyielding confidence lead Rachel into a heady realm of blissful abandon. Their exploration unfolds with an intoxicating blend of joyful abandon and tender intimacy.

The arrival of Jamie is the culmination of this passionate crescendo, an unexpected intensity that leaves Rachel breathless. Their connection is as much about power as about passion. As their embrace deepens, a poignant awareness of their shared vulnerability emerges.

They surrender to their shared desires, and the love between them is both unexpected and

profoundly moving.

Jackie's appearance marks a gentle transition, her calm presence hinting at the lasting memories of their shared evening; the night is still young, and the anticipation of the moments to come adds a thrilling layer to this tapestry of growing attraction. The night unfolds with a heady mixture of passionate abandon and tender intimacy, setting the stage for a weekend of unforgettable romance and shared intimacy.